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Bob Dylan crooned, “The times, they are a-changing”, and when it comes to desktop operating systems, indeed they are. Linux, which was once the choice of geeks, has undergone considerable changes. Gone are the days of grisly hardware compatibility, rudimentary graphic interfaces and negligible vendor support; it’s now time to enter the new world of Linux!

The last Linux comparison that we did was exactly 13 months ago; and in that short period, things have really moved to the next level. Newer versions of applications have come up, a lot of work has gone into making the Graphical User Interface (GUI) less intimidating, the Kernel has been spruced up, hardware databases have expanded and overall, using Linux is now an enjoyable experience.

Going by [www.distrowatch.com](http://www.distrowatch.com), there are thousands of distros (Linux distributions) available on the Internet for people to download. Each distribution is different from the other in the way it targets its audience. For example, there are distributions that are made specifically for testing network security—such a distribution has all the required tools for testing network security. However, apart from these esoteric flavours, most Linux distributions tend to be desktop centric.

Practically speaking, under the hood, almost all Linux distributions are similar since they end up using the same Kernel, application bundle, etc. There are several factors that go into making a distro better than the others, but the single factor that makes a huge impact is an ‘Active Community’. A community consists of the developers and users of that particular distribution. The developers make sure their distribution is up to date as far as security, bugs and new applications are concerned and the users make sure they provide the necessary feedback to the developers and help other novice users via forums.

On the desktop Linux front, having an active community does not cut it anymore; the distribution has to be polished in terms of look and feel and intuitiveness, since it will be judged alongside Microsoft’s Windows products.

In this comparison we have selected some of the best distros—free as well as paid. Ubuntu 6.06, Fedora Core 5, SuSE 10, Xandros, Mandriva 2006 and Knoppix 5 have been reviewed here.

Based on usage scenarios Linux distributions can be classified into three broad categories—Beginners, Power-users and Corporate.

Distributions aimed at beginners, like Xandros and Linspire focus on making the distro’s look and feel like Windows, so that first time users do not encounter a steep learning curve. This makes the transition from Windows to Linux much smoother for beginners. However, such distributions are made by companies, and hence are often paid propositions, which go against the basic philosophy of Linux being free.

On the other hand, powerusers like to be on the cutting edge and hence the focus is often to

provide the best there is in the Linux world. Such projects are community driven and are free to download and use. Distros like Gentoo, Open-SuSE and Fedora fall under this category.

Distributions aimed at the Corporate world, like RedHat and SuSE have an altogether different demand, such as ease of deployment, availability of patches, good technical support and basic sets of applications for office work. Addressing the corporate world requires dedicated resources and hence such distributions are paid—for the services offered, not the software.

## THE TEST Installation

Unlike Windows, installing Linux can be a challenge for many. The installer often gets quite technical and at times can be the biggest hurdle for the technologically challenged. Usage of terms such as sda1, hda1, swap, root, mount, etc., can confuse a novice.

Ubuntu 6.06 has done away with the quasi-graphical interface it had in the previous 5.10 version, which proved to be a stumbling block for many novices. In its latest incarnation, Ubuntu utilises a different approach—the Live CD itself doubles as the installation CD. What’s so good about this method? First, one can ascertain hardware compatibility before installation and second, it’s extremely straightforward and simple—any computer user will be able to install Ubuntu without any help. Six steps are what it takes to install Ubuntu 6.06, and that too in 10 minutes flat. During those six steps the installer prompts for basic information such as Locale settings, desired user name, password and partitioning details. We think the partitioning part still requires some polishing—it’s much better than the older version though. During our test, Ubuntu 6.06 was excellent at hardware detection and hence we like to call Ubuntu the ‘Pop it, install it and forget it’ distribution. A point to note is both our configuration were quite standard Intel boxes (assuming that’s what most Indian’s will have), people with ATI or NVIDIA chipsets might land up in some hardware issues. Note: earlier, a colleague had trouble installing the previous Ubuntu version on an ATI Radeon

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